



1636–37

“IT IS NOT ENOUGH TO HAVE A GOOD MIND; THE MAIN THING IS TO USE IT WELL.”

René Descartes, from *Discours de la Méthode*, 1637

same year, there was no Spanish New World treasure fleet. By now, the original causes of the Thirty Years' War had been superseded. **Habsburg weakness**, in Spain as much as in Germany, **was increasingly apparent**.

When not conspiring against his enemies, chief minister **Cardinal Richelieu** schemed to promote French prestige, or *gloire*. He championed colonial expansion, and **promoted French arts and learning**. Among his lasting achievements was the **Académie Française**, set up in 1635. Part of a pan-European move toward officially sanctioned institutes of learning, it was also **designed to consolidate** what France saw as one of its chief claims to *gloire*: **its language**. The Académie's 40 members continue to pronounce on language usage today.

In 1635, the system of *sankin kotai* (“alternate attendance”), **introduced to Japan** by Toyotomi Hideyoshi in the 1590s, was made compulsory. The daimyo (feudal lords) were forced to spend every other year at the shogun's court at Edo to participate in lavish rituals. The cost of such submission, plus the time spent at court, **made rebellion less likely**. When they returned to their estates, which they held from the shogun, each daimyo's wife and heir remained behind. **Exacting demands were enforced** regarding dress, types of weapons carried, soldier numbers accompanying each daimyo, and the contributions—military and financial—the daimyo were expected to provide.

Gondar Castle
Part of the Fasil Ghebbi, founded by Fasilides, in Ethiopia, this 17th-century castle shows Arab, Nubian, and Baroque design influences.



ETHIOPIAN EMPEROR since 1632, **Fasilides** (c. 1603–67) founded a permanent imperial capital at Gondar in 1636. The buildings he constructed there included the Fasil Ghebbi, a fortress complex that became **home to Ethiopia's emperors** until the 18th century. An early **speculative bubble burst** in February 1637, when the Dutch price of tulip bulbs peaked

One of the founders of modern philosophy, French writer **René Descartes** (1596–1650), an advocate of rationalism, produced *Discours de la Méthode* in 1637. It was one of the most influential works of Western philosophy.

1,000 PERCENT THE RELATIVE PRICE OF TULIP BULBS COMPARED TO THE ANNUAL INCOME OF A SKILLED DUTCH CRAFTSMAN

and then suddenly nose-dived, allegedly ruining many investors. A luxury item, they were seen as a safe haven for investment in an uncertain time. Although **Tulip Mania** prices are difficult to be certain about, and have been disputed, anecdotal evidence suggests significant highs.

A major new **encyclopedia**, *The Exploitation of the Works of Nature*, by minor provincial bureaucrat, **Song Yingxing**, was published in China in May 1637. Its wide range of information regarding Chinese technology distinguished it from earlier traditions, and provided an obvious and extensive resource.

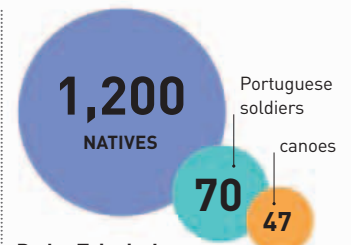
1638–39



This engraving depicts the Ottoman sultan, Murad IV, sitting on a horse. His reign restored internal authority and brought secure borders with Persia.

THE INTERMITTENT CONFLICT between the Ottoman Empire and the Safavid Persian Empire, which had begun in 1623, climaxed in 1638. **Baghdad fell to the Ottomans** under Sultan Murad IV (1612–40), the last Ottoman ruler to lead his troops in battle. This was followed in 1639 by the **Treaty of Qasr-i-Shirin**, which definitively settled the long-disputed Ottoman–Safavid border, largely to the benefit of the Ottomans. It granted all of **Mesopotamia** (modern Iraq) to the Ottomans, while handing the city of Yerevan (in present-day Armenia) to the Safavid Persians.

The problems that would eventually lead to the execution of **Charles I** of England in 1649 stemmed from the king's high-handed conviction that he could always impose himself on his kingdoms. This was not exclusively a matter of royal versus parliamentary authority. A significant element of **religious controversy** was involved, too. In 1637, Charles, encouraged by William Laud, the archbishop of Canterbury, had made the use of the **Church of England's Book of Common Prayer** compulsory in Scotland. Both Charles and Laud cordially despised the **Calvinist Scottish Kirk** (Church). For their part, Scotland's Kirk elders, much like their Puritan counterparts in England, considered any attempt to **impose Anglican religious uniformity** little better than papism. Their virulent protests in the following year, known as the **Great Covenant**, were followed in



Pedro Teixeira's Amazon expedition
Teixeira's expedition was immense and expensive. Of some political interest, it was financed by the governor of Maranhão, in Brazil.

1639 by the **invasion of England** by a “Covenanter” army **from Scotland**. The king's options were narrowing.

In 1638, **Portuguese explorer Pedro Teixeira** (d. 1641) achieved a remarkable double first in becoming the first person to make the **return journey of the entire length of the Amazon River**, reaching Belém, at the river's mouth, more than two years after he had set out. The previous year Teixeira had been the first person to make the journey upstream, a venture partly inspired by the need to know how far east **Spanish colonists** had advanced beyond the Andes and into the Amazon Basin.

On November 24, 1639, English astronomer **Jeremiah Horrocks** (1618–41) became the first person to both predict and observe a **transit of Venus**. This rare event sees Venus pass directly between the Sun and the Earth. Observing the transit provided information vital to calculating the distance from the Earth to the Sun.

1635 Sankin kotai system introduced in Japan
1635 English colony of Connecticut established in North America
April 1635 France declares war on Habsburg Spain
December 25, 1635 French explorer Samuel de Champlain dies (b. c. 1567)

1636 France declares war on Holy Roman Empire
1636 King Fasilides founds Ethiopian capital at Gondar
February 1637 Tulip Mania bubble collapses in Netherlands
1637 French philosopher René Descartes writes *Discours de la Méthode*
1637 Song Yingxing writes *The Exploitation of the Works of Nature*
1638 Rhode Island, in North America, settled by English
1637 Anglican prayer book imposed on Scotland

1638 Dutch and Portuguese drive Sri Lanka
1638 Ottomans led by Murad IV retake Baghdad from Safavids
1638 Christian Shimabara Rebellion in Japan suppressed
1638 Pedro Teixeira explores full length of Amazon River
May 1639 Scottish Covenanters invade England
May 1639 Treaty of Qasr-i-Shirin between Ottomans and Safavids
November 24, 1639 English astronomer Jeremiah Horrocks observes transit of Venus
1639 Russian explorers reach Pacific coast of Siberia